

COOL

NEW AND ADAPTIVE DESIGN
ACROSS AMERICA

IS



EVERY WHERE

MICHEL
ARNAUD

CITY OF ASYLUM

Diane Samuels and her husband, Henry Reese, started the Pittsburgh branch of the Cities of Asylum program in 2004. A nonprofit that began in Europe as a way to help writers who are threatened in their own countries, both physically and professionally, Cities of Asylum promotes free-speech protections. At the time, Samuels and Reese were living in Pittsburgh's North Side neighborhood, where they bought a row house nearby and offered a writer from China, Huang Xiang, a two-year residency. From there, the program grew to include public events such as readings and concerts. Nowadays, City of Asylum has a collection of buildings throughout the neighborhood as well as a garden. Their most recent purchase was a former Masonic Temple that has been turned into a cultural center, complete with a café, a bookstore, offices, and rooms for performances.



ABOVE Chinese poet Huang Xiang wrote one of his poems on the outside of his City of Asylum residence. This action started the tradition of asking artists to make text-based imagery on the exterior of the residence, which enlivens the alley where they are.

RIGHT *Pittsburgh-Burma House* by artist Than Htay Maung, who is the husband of City of Asylum resident writer Khet Mar, is part of the House Publications of City of Asylum.

OPPOSITE, ABOVE The Alphabet Reading Garden is part of City of Asylum's creative placemaking programming. The garden was designed by architect Joel Le Gall, artist Laura Jean McLaughlin, and artist and City of Asylum cofounder Diane Samuels. The garden has artworks made with images of alphabets.

OPPOSITE, BELOW A former Masonic Temple was turned into City of Asylum's cultural center.



